



The FamilyPause Guide

*A simple weekly planning system for
families with too much going on.*

Written by Spencer Longmore
Founder & CEO

Why weekly family planning fails

I'll be the first to admit it. I'm managing my own schedule, my wife is managing hers, and as much as she tries to update me by text or in passing, the system isn't concrete. So the event doesn't make it onto the calendar as consistently as it should.

Why not just sit down every week? Because right when we plan to, a kid cuts their arm, or one of us says yes to a last-minute playdate and forgets the meeting entirely. Or it's Sunday, we're both home from church, and it's the first real chance we've had to talk or rest all week — so we rest. Then it's dinner, then it's time to leave for evening service.

Life is busy. But this is our life, and we know how much it matters to stay on the same page. Otherwise the information lives scattered across five places: texts, school emails, memory, two calendars, and one person's head. Whoever holds it all becomes the bottleneck.

Four steps. Five minutes instead of forty.

So we built our own system, believing the whole process could be more efficient with modern technology. The method is four steps, and it's deliberately product agnostic.

One. Capture everything in one place.

Two. Sort it into a plan.

Three. Review it together.

Four. Put it on the calendar.

That's the flow FamilyPause runs on, but it's also something anyone can do with paper and a pen. FamilyPause just makes it take five minutes instead of forty.

We actually encourage keeping your own habit of writing things down. The time saver isn't in changing how you capture information — it's in getting what you wrote into FamilyPause so it can sort it and sync straight to your calendar.

Two calendars, no shared picture

You've got your calendar, your spouse has theirs, and somewhere in between is the actual truth of this week. Two people living two schedules just struggle to hold one shared picture. Then an appointment gets missed and you're both humbled into a reset.

Thirty minutes, once a week, together. But scheduling isn't the real value for couples — that's why we made the Conversation Starter Cards. "What did I do last week that made you feel most loved by me?" The reflection is the point.

Then move on to the week. Let FamilyPause sort it, and you walk away with one list instead of two halves.

You mention the dentist appointment you forgot to tell your spouse about. They mention a retirement dinner they already said yes to. Both are on the calendar before you stand up.

Inputs arrive as noise

If you're raising kids, information doesn't come to you in order. It comes at you. A school app notification here, a group text there, a flyer stuffed in a backpack, a hallway conversation with another parent you meant to write down and didn't. None of it arrives when you're ready for it, and most of it gets remembered halfway.

So stop trying to sort things as they land. Open FamilyPause, type or say the thing, save it — a text, an email, or something you just remembered while making dinner. You don't need to organize it yet. Just capture it. Sort once, at the end of the week, when you actually have a few minutes to sit with it.

Monday, the school emails about a half day you didn't know about. Wednesday, another parent mentions a birthday party in passing. Thursday, you remember the permission slip. None of it gets sorted in the moment. Sunday you sit down and it comes out as one clear week instead of three scattered memories.

Decisions get made, then evaporate

If you're building something, work doesn't stay in its lane. It shows up at dinner. It shows up in the car. You and your spouse end up making real decisions about events, reminders and plans in the middle of conversations that were never meant to be meetings — and because none of it was written down, some of it gets forgotten.

So capture the decision the moment the conversation ends. Not later, not when you remember. If the two of you just talked through something that matters, business or family, take thirty seconds right then and get it into FamilyPause before it's gone.

You're washing dishes and the two of you land on something real — moving a trip that overlaps a work deadline. In the old system that decision lives in your head until someone remembers it. In this one, you say it out loud into FamilyPause and it's captured and synced before the next thing pulls your attention away.

Curriculum and life share one calendar

If you're homeschooling, you're not just managing a family calendar. You're managing a school calendar that lives inside your family calendar. Lessons, appointments, activities and everyday life all fight for the same square inch of space, and school has a way of quietly swallowing everything else.

As a homeschool family for the past fifteen years, we know this one well. Sort by person and by category, not just by date. School stays organized as its own thing without taking over the whole week, and the rest of family life doesn't get crowded out just because it wasn't labeled urgent.

A math unit due Friday, a dentist appointment Wednesday, a family outing you've been planning for weeks. Sorted by person and category, all three sit side by side. The outing is on the shared calendar before anyone books a work lunch over it — so the whole family makes the fall co-op apple picking trip.

You want depth, not just logistics

Some families aren't only trying to solve a scheduling problem. You want the weekly pause to actually mean something — a real conversation, not a to-do list with extra steps. Logistics matter, but if that's all the meeting ever becomes, you lose the part that made you want to sit down together in the first place.

So open with a conversation starter card before you run the capture. Let the first few minutes be about each other, not the calendar. Then, once you've actually talked, move into capturing what needs to get done.

You pull a card that asks how you feel about the amount of screen time in your home right now — for the kids and for you. You talk it through, really talk, not rushed. Then you move into the capture and the calendar gets built. Two people talking, not two schedules meeting.

The system works with or without us

Everything in this guide works with a notebook. You don't need us for any of it. Capture what's going on, sort it, review it together, put it on the calendar. That's the whole system.

What FamilyPause does is take the part that eats up your time and hand it back to you. You still talk, you still write or say what's on your mind. But instead of spending forty minutes sorting it out by hand, it takes about five. It finds the appointments, the tasks, the reminders and the decisions, and gets them ready for your calendar so you can review together and move on with your week.

If you want to try it, start a free trial and see how it feels with your own week, your own list, your own family. No pressure either way. We just built the fastest way to run it.

Start your free trial at familypause.com

THE CHALLENGE

Try the system once this week

You don't need to overhaul anything. Just run it once and see what happens.

- ☐ Pick a day you can actually sit down together. Sunday works for a lot of families.
 - ☐ Before you talk logistics, pull a conversation starter card and let the first few minutes be about each other.
 - ☐ Capture everything on your mind — type it, write it, or say it. Don't sort it yet.
 - ☐ Let FamilyPause sort it into a plan — by person, by category, whatever fits your family.
 - ☐ Review it together. Confirm what's right, fix what's missing.
 - ☐ Put it on the calendar. One you both share, of course.
-

*"Two are better than one, because they have
a good return for their labor."*

ECCLESIASTES 4:9